

Meltdown Management Guide

For Parents of Children with Autism & Sensory Differences

What is a Meltdown?

A meltdown is NOT a tantrum. It is a neurological response to sensory overload. The child has genuinely lost control and cannot reason, respond, or calm down by willpower. They need SAFETY, not discipline.

BEFORE a Meltdown — Early Warning Signs

- Increased stimming (rocking, hand flapping)
- Covering ears or eyes
- Repetitive questions or statements
- Increased heart rate and breathing
- Refusal to follow instructions
- Seeking tight spaces or pressure
- Voice becoming higher pitched
- Avoiding eye contact completely

DURING a Meltdown — Step by Step

Step	Action	What to Do
Step 1	STAY CALM	Your calm is contagious. Take a breath. Lower your voice.
Step 2	ENSURE SAFETY	Remove dangerous objects. Move child to a safe space.
Step 3	REDUCE STIMULATION	Turn off lights/TV. Reduce noise. Less is more.
Step 4	GIVE SPACE	Don't force hugs. Don't make demands. Just be present.
Step 5	USE FEW WORDS	"I'm here. You're safe." Short, simple, calm.
Step 6	WAIT IT OUT	Meltdowns pass. Average duration: 5-30 minutes.
Step 7	RECONNECT GENTLY	After calm: "That was hard. I love you. You're safe."

NEVER Do This During a Meltdown

- ✗ Punish, threaten or raise your voice
- ✗ Try to reason or explain consequences
- ✗ Force eye contact or touch
- ✗ Take away special items or interests
- ✗ Say "Stop it" or "Calm down" — they physically cannot
- ✗ Discuss the meltdown in the moment

AFTER a Meltdown — Recovery

- ✓ Give quiet, non-demanding time to recover

- ✓ Offer a preferred snack or drink (dehydration worsens meltdowns)
- ✓ Reconnect with a calm activity or show together
- ✓ Note the trigger in a diary — patterns help prevent future meltdowns
- ✓ Never use the meltdown as a teaching moment immediately after